Modi has led from the front in this regard. His initiative in 2015 to globally celebrate yoga has been phenomenally successful. The propagation of our medical and wellness practices has also gained traction. When it comes to environment, the advocacy of lifestyle changes is being widely welcomed. Even food habits are relevant in this regard, reflected in the Indian endeavour to lead greater cultivation and consumption of millets, our ancient grains. Some of this is expressed through the optics of how the leadership carries itself and expresses its views.

A large part of the challenge that still needs more effective redressal is in the deeper concepts and entrenched assumptions of contemporary international relations. That is still work in progress but hopefully one that will see improvements in the coming years.

Yet another notable feature of the Modi-era diplomacy has been its people-centric approach. There were multiple drivers for this greater emphasis on the human factor. One, of course, was the external reflection of a domestic campaign to improve development indices and extend social welfare. Supporting Indians abroad is a natural extrapolation of this approach.

Another is the understanding that India needed to prepare for the requirements of the knowledge economy. It was essential to envisage a global workplace, not just a trading place. And that meant working out the requisite institutional arrangements and practices rather than leaving our citizens at the mercy of the vagaries of the mobility industry.

Then, there was greater consciousness about the importance and contribution of Indians abroad, be they students, professionals or those more settled. Their welfare was envisaged as an obligation that should be addressed with utmost seriousness. And finally, there was a sense of a changing India itself. A rising power should not leave its people abroad to face adversity on their own. Such detachment not only reflects badly on our standing but could also undermine the faith with which Indians could proceed abroad.

Instituting robust welfare measures applicable beyond our borders, extricating our citizens from crisis situations and organizing repatriations as they happened during the Covid pandemic are all steps in that direction. Indeed, the transformation begins right at home with radical reforms in the ease of issuing passports. This was paralleled by initiatives to facilitate mobility while ensuring that Indians were not treated in a discriminatory